

THE LONG RIDE CM Bhajan Lal Sharma during a visit to Shergarh, rural Jodhpur, in early July

an acute need to do something every now and then to scoop himself out of an image trough. Two, he does manage that reasonably emphatically, with implicit central backing being the gold reserve for his currency. Witness only his latest reassertion of control.

On July 19, in his third major bureaucratic shake-up, the CM transferred 91 IPS and 58 state administrative officers. This followed the July 3 appointment of Rajeev Kumar Sharma as Director General of Police. The officer he replaces, U.K. Sahoo, himself a Sharma government appointee, was earlier moved to the scandal-ridden Rajasthan Public Service Commission.

Also last month, 62 IAS officers were transferred, including senior ones; slowly but surely, younger cadre are being elevated. All of this is meant to chip away at the narrative that chases him: of him being indecisive and too accommodating of bureaucrats linked to the previous Congress regime.

Speaking exclusively to INDIA TODAY, Sharma was measured in his tone: "I take criticism calmly, but there comes a point—enough is enough." He says he "judged the performance" of senior officers, and that dictated his moves. Insiders say the reshuffle reflects feedback from the Centre, the BJP brass, the RSS and ministers. Several officers perceived as powerful or well-connected have been sidelined. "I want officers to attend to public grievances on priority. No compromise," he says. DGP Sharma's immediate action—sacking four constables in Jodhpur involved in kidnapping and extortion—sent precisely such a signal.

Takeaways

- **In a reassertion of his authority, Sharma effects mass IPS, IAS transfers**
- **It's an ongoing battle to bolster his image amidst an unceasing anti campaign**

The Beniwal affair was another such. He was piqued because the government issued him and his brother Narayan Beniwal notices to vacate official houses allotted to them as MLAs, which both had long ceased to be. That was preceded by an order to cut power at Beniwal's Nagaur residence, which is in the name of another brother, for not paying dues of Rs 11 lakh.

There's another grouse: Beniwal's demand that the cheating scam-tainted 2021 Sub-Inspector recruitment exam be cancelled. The state's legal stand has been that punishing everyone selected would be unjust, as only 50 of 859 have been arrested so far.

Beniwal's party has no MLAs presently, so Sharma knows there's no real danger there. Gehlot and Raje, of course, could any day turn into a moving Birnam Wood—but facing that is part of his job description. ■